



INNOVATION

REAL INNOVATION SOLVES REAL PROBLEMS

JANANI GOPALAKRISHNAN VIKRAM



AirBar is a discreet device that fits below your laptop display and transforms it into a touchscreen

Transform any laptop screen into a touchscreen

Price, glare and battery drain are three reasons that could discourage you from buying a touchscreen laptop. Neonode has developed a simple but innovative USB-powered device that can transform any ordinary laptop into a touchscreen one at a fraction of the cost.

A CES 2017 Innovation Awards Honouree, **AirBar** is a sleek matte-finished strip that attaches to the bottom of your laptop screen using magnets, and plugs into the nearest USB port. That's it—no calibration or software installation required. Now, AirBar starts projecting an invisible light field on the surface of your display that makes it possible to use it like a touchscreen. You can interact with your laptop using Windows gestures like pinch, swipe, zoom and scroll. Unlike regular touchscreen laptops, you can use AirBar 'touchscreen' with anything—bare hands, gloved hands, a pen, a paintbrush, stylus or whatever. This is because the light field reacts to any disturbance without requiring any minimal touch activation force.

AirBar does away with glare too. Light transmission is 100 per cent as nothing is built atop or inside your screen. There is just an invisible light field being emitted from the bar.

AirBar comes in three different sizes to suit different screen sizes: 33.8cm (13.3-inch), 35.6cm (14-inch) and 39.6cm (15.6-inch). It works on all Windows 10 laptops. There is also a version compatible with MacBook Air 33.8cm. Currently, AirBar does not work with some devices like MacBook Pro because it requires at least 17mm of space below the display to snap on. However, the company has just revealed to EYF that they are planning to expand their suite of products to fit additional laptops such as MacBook Pro.

Company: Neonode; **Country:** Stockholm, Sweden; **Website:** www.air.bar

One charger for your Android and Apple devices

If a project gets 61.7 per cent funding on Indiegogo, it must solve a real problem for people! **Magbine** is one such interesting product—a charger that works for Android and Apple devices, as well as other devices with a Micro USB port. It reduces the cable clutter at home and on-the-go as you need just one charger for your many devices.

The charger's patent-granted multi-device connector comes with a reversible tip, so Apple users need not bother about identifying the correct side to push in their charger! Made with a special material, it is durable and tangle-free.



Do away with your cable clutter using Magbine (Image courtesy: Magbine)

Company: Magbine; **Country:** Hong Kong, China; **Website:** <https://www.indiegogo.com/projects/magbine-first-magnetic-cable-for-all-devices-iphone-android-2#/>

True wireless charging

Experts who witnessed the demo of Energo Corporation's **WattUp** claim it to be the future of wireless charging. With WattUp, there are no constraints like the need to place the product on a mat. You can wear your devices or keep them in your bag as they get charged. This revolutionary radio frequency (RF) based charging solution works by delivering intelligent, scalable power to devices via radio bands, similar to a Wi-Fi router.

Depending on the variant you choose, WattUp can charge devices at distances between a millimetre and 4.6m (15 feet). It can charge multiple battery-powered devices in its proximity, including smartphones, tablets, wearable devices, cameras, keyboards, headsets, sensors, toys and remote controls.

The WattUp transmitter sends energy through RF transmission signals upon request. The amount of power delivered and transmission distance are determined by the size



WattUp enables you to charge multiple devices in a truly wireless fashion (Image courtesy: Energo Corporation)

of the transmitter and the number of transmitter ASICs and antennae used in the design. WattUp receivers installed in the devices convert signals into battery power. The entire system is controlled by a software, which lets you decide which devices are to be charged, in which order and at what times. If you do not want to get into the details, you can just let the software intelligently manage the charging of all your WattUp enabled devices.

Company: Energo Corporation; **Country:** United States of America; **Website:** <http://energo.com/>